up in the BJP's favour,' is how I described on television the election mood after the assembly elections.

The belt from Maharashtra in the west to Bihar in the north had 314 seats across fourteen small and large states. In 2009, the Congress had won 116 seats here, the BJP just eighty-nine. Now, the BJP needed to not just reverse that scoreline but virtually dominate this entire region and get a strike rate of at least 70 per cent of these seats, if not more. The key to fulfilling what seemed a highly ambitious target lay in the Indo-Gangetic plain, in the prized states of UP and Bihar. With 120 seats between them—UP with eighty and Bihar with forty—it was in these two states that Modi would now have to fight his biggest battle if he wanted to be India's next prime minister.